

43 Making deductions

In English, you can add an extra verb (called a “modal verb”) to show if a statement is likely or unlikely. You may hear modal verbs when people talk about sickness.

⚙️ **New language** “Might” and “could”

Aa **Vocabulary** Health and sickness

🧑 **New skill** Talking about possibility

43.1 KEY LANGUAGE “MIGHT” AND “COULD”

The modal verbs “might” and “could” are useful for saying that you’re not sure about something.

Use “might” and “could” when something is not certain.

John has a sore ankle. It **{ might
could }** be broken.

The modal verb doesn’t change with the subject.

The modal verb is usually followed by the base form of the main verb.



Use “might not” to describe a negative that is not certain.

It’s not very swollen, so it **might not** be serious.

“Not” sits after the modal verb.



Use “could not” and “couldn’t” to say that something was not possible in the past.

His ankle was so sore yesterday that he **{ could not
couldn’t }** walk.



Use “cannot” and “can’t” when you’re certain something is impossible.

It **{ cannot
can’t }** be broken because John walked to the doctor.



43.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES “MIGHT” AND “COULD”

Fay’s got a sore throat and isn’t feeling well. She **might** have a cold.



I was so sick last week that I **couldn’t** get out of bed.



My eyes are itchy and I have a runny nose. It **could** be hay fever.



I **can’t** have the flu because I don’t have a high temperature.

